

INDIA AT 60

◀◀ REWIND

FREEDOM AT A COST

CAVING IN: A relieved Mufti hugs his daughters Rubaiya and Mehbooba

The end of the six-day drama of the kidnapping of Rubaiya Sayeed—daughter of Union home minister Mufti Mohammad Sayeed—was a case of good news, and then the bad news. While the 23-year-old doctor was brought back safely, it was only after the exchange of five members of JKLF who were released to secessionist slogans (“if you wish to do God’s work, go pick up a Kalashnikov”). As the government blinked first, the separatist movement grew in Kashmir, leading to more kidnappings and killings.

SEEDS OF DISCORD

The first stone for building the Ram Mandir was laid at the disputed Babri Masjid site on November 9. In Ayodhya, over two lakh Hindus pledged their lives for the cause of Ram Janmabhoomi, while in Delhi an equal number of Muslims swore to protect the structure. The Government watched, sitting on a keg of communal gunpowder.

FIRST CUT

● Kottayam in Kerala became the first town in the country to achieve complete literacy. All 70,000 citizens in this small southern town can read and write.

● Rajiv Gandhi became the first Indian prime minister to visit Pakistan, but lost soon after, the Congress winning only 197 seats in Lok Sabha, 200 down from 1984.

◀◀ DID YOU KNOW

The National Front victory saw oversized egos clashing after Devi Lal said he wanted the top spot. If not that, he asked for the second-best post, that of deputy prime minister. His wish was fulfilled.